PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Antietam — A House Divided

When the Camera Went to the Dead

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Antietam — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. A photograph feels like pure truth. A historian asks harder questions: who made it, why, and what is outside the frame?

THE SOURCES

SOURCE A · THE PHOTOGRAPH — The dead near the Dunker Church



Confederate dead in a row near the Dunker Church, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE B · A SECOND PHOTOGRAPH — Along the Hagerstown Pike



Confederate dead along the Hagerstown Pike fence, Antietam — photograph by Alexander Gardner, September 1862, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE C · THE NEW YORK TIMES · OCTOBER 1862 — The public reaction

> *"Mr. Brady has done something to bring home to us the terrible reality … of war. … These pictures have a terrible distinctness. By the aid of the magnifying-glass, the very features of the slain may be distinguished."*
> *— The New York Times, October 20, 1862. Public domain*

— The New York Times, October 20, 1862. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · OBSERVE

Look carefully at Source A. List three specific things you can observe in the photograph. Then describe how it makes you feel — and why.

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE POWER OF THE NEW SOURCE

Before 1862, the public saw war through paintings and heroic lithographs. Using Source C, why did Brady's photographs affect people so differently?

- ☐ A. photographs looked like undeniable reality — the actual faces of the actual dead
- ☐ B. photographs were in bright color

☐ C. photographs made the war look glorious

☐ D. no one actually went to the exhibition

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · EVIDENCE HAS AN AUTHOR

Historians have shown that Gardner sometimes rearranged a scene — even moving a body — to make a more powerful picture. Does that mean his photographs are not good historical evidence? Explain what they still prove, and what we must be careful about.

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

In two or three sentences: how did photographs like these change the way Americans understood the war — and why is it important that, from 1862 on, the public could finally see it?

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Antietam — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I observe: 1)... 2)... 3)... It makes me feel... because..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — A. photographs looked like undeniable reality — the actual faces of the actual dead**

Right. A photograph carried a 'terrible distinctness' — it looked like unarguable reality, the real faces of the real dead, not an artist's flattering version. That made the war impossible to romanticize.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The photographs still prove... But we must be careful because..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Seeing the war changed Americans because..."